

Salary Negotiation, Script Included

Word-for-word scripts for negotiating CTC,
raises, and counter-offers.

Before we start

Negotiation feels uncomfortable mostly because people improvise it. Having an actual script removes most of the anxiety — you're not making it up on the spot, you're running a plan. Adjust the wording to sound like you, but keep the structure.

1. Research before you say a number

- **Check 3-5 sources** for market rate — salary comparison sites, LinkedIn posts from people in similar roles, and direct conversations with peers in the same industry.
- **Know your walk-away number** — the minimum you'd genuinely accept — before the conversation starts, so you're not deciding under pressure in real time.
- **List your leverage honestly.** A competing offer is strong leverage. Vague "I've been doing a lot" is weak leverage. Know which one you actually have.

2. Negotiating a new job offer

The initial counter

"Thank you for the offer — I'm genuinely excited about the role and the team. Based on my experience with [specific skills/scope] and current market rates for this role, I was hoping we could look at [target number] for the base. Is there flexibility here?"

If they say "this is our best offer"

"I understand budgets can be fixed on base salary. Is there flexibility elsewhere — a joining bonus, an earlier review cycle, or additional equity — that could help bridge the gap?"

If you have a competing offer

"I want to be upfront — I have another offer at [number], and I'd genuinely prefer to join here given [specific reason: team, growth, product]. Is there room to get closer to that number?"

Note: only use this if the competing offer is real. Bluffing a number you can't produce if asked can seriously damage trust if it unravels.

3. Negotiating a raise

Opening the conversation

"I'd like to set up some time to discuss my compensation. Over the past [timeframe], I've [1-2 concrete outcomes, with numbers if possible]. Could we find 20-30 minutes this week or next?"

If your manager says there's no budget right now

"I understand budget cycles are a real constraint. Could we agree on a specific number and a timeline for when this could be revisited — the next review cycle, or a specific quarter?"

This converts a vague "not now" into a concrete, trackable commitment, which is far more useful than leaving it open-ended.

If you're told to "wait for the annual review"

"That works — could we document the specific outcomes we're discussing today, so they're part of that review conversation rather than something I have to re-raise from scratch?"

4. Negotiating beyond the base number

Component	What to ask
Joining bonus	"Is there room for a joining bonus to bridge the gap, even if the base stays where it is?"
Work location/WFH	"Is remote or hybrid flexibility available for this role, and if so, how is it structured?"
Designation	"Given the scope of this role, is [specific title] on the table instead of [offered title]?"
Notice period buyout	"Would the company be able to cover or partially cover my notice period buyout with my current employer?"
ESOPs/equity	"Could you share more on the vesting schedule and current valuation basis for the equity component?"

5. Mistakes that weaken your position

- **Naming a number first** without research — anchor too low and you leave money on the table; anchor with no basis and you lose credibility.
- **Accepting on the spot.** "Let me review this and get back to you by [specific date]" is always a reasonable, professional response.
- **Making it personal** ("I need more money because rent went up") instead of value-based ("here's the impact I've delivered") — the second is what companies actually respond to.
- **Not getting the final number in writing** before resigning from a current role or declining another offer.

6. Quick answers to common questions

Is it okay to negotiate a first job offer?

Generally yes, though the room to negotiate is often smaller for entry-level roles than for experienced hires. A polite, research-backed ask rarely damages an offer.

What if I don't have a competing offer to use as leverage?

Lead with value delivered or market research instead — you don't need a competing offer to negotiate, just a credible reason.

How many rounds of back-and-forth is reasonable?

Typically 1-2 rounds. Beyond that, diminishing returns set in, and it's worth deciding whether the current number is genuinely acceptable.

7. Before you negotiate

- ✓ Research market rate from at least 3 sources.
- ✓ Decide your target number and your walk-away number in advance.
- ✓ List concrete outcomes or value delivered, with numbers where possible.
- ✓ Pick which non-salary components matter most to you, in case base salary has no room.
- ✓ Practice saying your opening line out loud at least once before the actual conversation.

These scripts are starting points — adjust tone and specifics to match your role, industry, and relationship with the other party.